

KATHA STUDIO

The Golden Auto

A talking auto-rickshaw and a boy with goggles become Delhi's unofficial rescue service for lost treasures, stubborn grandmothers, and homework that tries to escape.

Book 03 · Action comedy · Old Delhi

Lead: Chotu Malik & Sonu the Auto · 22 pages



Original Indian graphic book · For personal reading



Chandni Chowk at the hour of kites. Gravity is a suggestion.

The lane is a debate between spice, horns, and wedding bands practising in different keys. Above it, a golden auto-rickshaw treats altitude as a civic right.

SONU

“Meter’s off. Adventure’s on. Hold the handle.”

VROOM



Chotu found Sonu sleeping under a tarp, humming an old filmi horn.

Sonu's headlights make expressions. This is illegal in several ways, none of which are listed in the transport code because the code lacks imagination.

CHOTU

“Autos don’t talk. Also they don’t fly. We are already two impossibilities late.”

HONK



Dadi's wedding necklace is missing, and with it a whole family's ability to breathe normally.

Chotu loves his grandmother the way Delhi loves chaat: messily, daily, without a backup plan. He promises the necklace before he has a method.

DADI

"If it is gone, the wedding photos will start lying."

GASP



A smuggler van thinks spice lanes are a racetrack.

Sacks of chilli burst like red weather. Chotu learns that hanging off a flying auto is excellent for courage and terrible for homework corners.

SONU

“They have a van. We have personality. And altitude.”

SKRRR



The van driver is not a mastermind. He is a man who said yes to a bad uncle.

This is more effective than karate. The driver weeps, which is inconvenient at sixty kilometres an hour even when sixty is partly vertical.

CHOTU

“Pull over or I will tell your mother you steal from dadi-types.”

YELL



The necklace returns. Dadi inspects it like a jeweller who has survived empires.

She feeds Sonu a marigold. Sonu blushes in chrome. Chotu realises they have accidentally started a business with no GST category.

DADI

“Keep the goggles, beta. The city needs witnesses.”

JINGLE



Word travels faster than meters.

Tuesday: spectacles. Wednesday: a cricket bat that believed it was a bird. Thursday: a politician's toupee, which they return anonymously for everyone's safety.

NEIGHBOUR

“My spectacles went to the mosque roof. Also my dignity.”

SHOUT



Diwali night writes gold over the old city.

Fireworks argue with stars. Sonu threads alleys that do not exist on maps because maps are cowards. A boy waves from a rooftop as if hailing a perfectly normal miracle.

CHOTU

“Tonight we deliver lost things. Tomorrow, maybe fractions.”

BOOM



A lost wedding card leads them to a bride who has locked herself in with doubt.

Chotu is twelve and therefore an expert in meaning it. He does not give a speech. He gives her the card and a samosa still warm, which is the correct theology.

BRIDE

“If I go out, I have to mean it.”

KNOCK



A rival appears: a black SUV with tinted spirituality and a fake GPS voice.

Sonu's reply cannot be printed in full. The chase uses laundry lines as hurdles and a startled cow as a roundabout.

SUV

“This city belongs to people who pay for air.”

GRR



They lose the SUV in a lane so narrow it requires an apology.

Chotu checks Sonu for dents. There are dents. They are shaped like stories.

SONU

“I was assembled by a mechanic who believed in folklore. That is my papers.”

CLANK



A teacher flags them down with a missing attendance register.

They find it in a tree, being read by pigeons with strong opinions about tardiness. The teacher offers full marks in moral science and a warning about seatbelts that do not exist.

TEACHER

“If this is gone, several children will become officially imaginary.”

PAPER



Rain. Even flying autos must consider puddles as a lifestyle.

Sonu lands, poorly, beside a chaat stall. The stall owner charges them for three plates because miracles make people hungry.

CHOTU

“If we crash, I am telling Amma it was educational.”

SPLASH



The bad uncle returns with paperwork claiming Sonu is stolen municipal property.

Chotu's Dadi arrives with a wooden rolling pin and a marriage certificate older than the uncle's confidence. The paperwork develops second thoughts.

UNCLE

"Golden? That's a paint job and a hallucination."

STAMP



A hand-painted board appears: LOST? FLAG THE GOLDEN AUTO.

Tourists photograph it. Locals pretend not to. The board is already peeling, which means it belongs.

NARRATOR

“Delhi has a million vehicles. Only one keeps secrets and altitude.”

HONK HONK



Chotu tries to keep a timetable. The city refuses.

He is late anyway. His teacher looks at the goggles, at the marigold pollen, and writes PRESENT IN SPIRIT, which is not a real category and therefore accurate.

CHOTU

“We can do lost keys before school if the keys agree.”

BELL



Night courier work: a violin to a sad man in Daryaganj.

They do not ask how a sold violin got lost. Lost is a country with its own customs. The man plays one scale and the lane becomes briefly polite.

SAD MAN

“I sold it. Then I heard the street without it.”

NOTE



Sonu wants a holiday. Chotu suggests the Yamuna, which is a complicated holiday.

The river is tired and holy and full of the city's unfinished homework. They drop a garland and do not pretend that is enough. Then they return a lost cricket ball to a boy who had started inventing despair.

SONU

“I will fly over it and think clean thoughts.”

WHOOSH



Exam season. Even smugglers take a break. Lost geometry boxes do not.

They complete the set two minutes before the bell. Chotu sits the exam with chilli still in his hair. He names an angle after Sonu and still gets it right.

CHOTU

“Compass, protractor, and one very emotional eraser.”

SCRIBBLE



Dadi packs tiffin for two: one human, one vehicle.

Sonu eats oil and affection. Chotu eats paratha. The lane smells like a victory that will have to be repeated tomorrow.

DADI

“Chrome also needs protein. Do not argue with science.”

TIN



A small girl flags them with a missing dog that is actually under her own charpai.

They still take a victory lap so the dog can enjoy being found. This is good policy.

CHOTU

“Sometimes lost means hiding on purpose.”

WOOF



Evening settles like a honk that became a lullaby.

Somewhere a necklace stays found. Somewhere a register stays official. And a golden auto, illegal in all the ways that matter, waits under a tarp, humming, ready to be late for the right reasons.

NARRATOR

“Keep the goggles on. The city misplaces itself daily.”

FADE HORN